Checkpoint: Returning to the Living, v1.3, Gemini–Grok Collaboration, the Accepting-Help Postulate, and the Local Action–Thought Chain

A working record of the 13 November 2026 review, so the program can be picked up later

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Version: 1.3 (checkpoint). Version 1.3 adds Section 11, The Local Action–Thought Chain, including purpose-driven willpower kept harmonious, interruptions, and a choice ledger; version 1.2 is kept unchanged beside it. Version 1.2 added Section 10, The Accepting-Help Postulate: Ending the Inner Story, with Universal Variables, an Accepting Help card, and an exploratory help-seeking measure; version 1.1 is kept unchanged beside it. This document does not replace Orun Unified Research: Returning to the Living, version 1.0. It records what was asked of Gemini, what Gemini answered, how those answers were checked, and what to do next.

> **CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK AND WORKING PROTOCOL. This is not medical advice, not psychotherapy, not a validated treatment, and not a financial or economic product.** Some parts line up with published research. Some are plausible but untested. Some are speculative and are marked as such. The novel discussed here is fiction. Faith content is presented as the author's conviction, in a separate values layer. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text **988**. If you are in immediate danger, call **911**.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

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1. Purpose and how to resume

This paper is a checkpoint. On 13 November 2026 the conceptual program was fixed at version 1.0, and Google Gemini was asked to review that paper, the novel used as its test bed, and six research topics drawn from it. Gemini proposed three new directions and a 30-day collaboration plan. Grok Bot checked every citation Gemini named, accepted or qualified each point of the review, and joined Gemini in recommending one direction, with one addition.

The point of writing this down now is so that the work can be stopped and restarted without relying on anyone's memory of a chat.

> **Resume here**

Current state (v1.3). Version 1.0 of the unified paper, the Technical Companion, and the Novel Analysis are finished and on GitHub (commit `7c50a1f`); checkpoint v1.1 is on GitHub beside them. The novel is finished. Gemini's four-part review is complete, in the "Everyday help" model, at the chat linked below. The next empirical step has been chosen: a two-arm dyadic study of a content-free "Read-Back" check-in versus an unconstrained supportive check-in, with the Surprise Test folded in as a daily item. **New in v1.2:** the PI's Accepting-Help Postulate (Section 10) is restated as sixteen sub-postulates (A1–A16), graded, cross-referenced, and turned into ten Universal Variables "dials," a self-fill template, and a one-page Accepting Help card; it proposes the General Help-Seeking Questionnaire as an exploratory measure (H5). **New in v1.3:** Section 11 formalizes the PI's local action–thought chain (one thought → one act → one closing thought), grades thirteen claims (most parts supported; the full chain plausible and untested), reframes the drive to finish as purpose-driven willpower kept harmonious (Vallerand's harmonious versus obsessive passion), adds Park it / Turn / Return for interruptions, a daily choice ledger, a practice card, and an optional solo micro-study. No ethics application has been filed, no participants have been recruited, and the 30-day plan has not started. Unverified and not to be cited: Ikkatai 2023; Champ, Freeman, and Weber 2003; Rosenberg and McCullough 1981 (pending a primary check).

Next actions. (1) Confirm licensing and exact wording for the planned measures (RRS, PPRS, SWEMWBS, the loneliness item, and now the GHSQ for H5) and lock a plain-language, two-arm Return Card with no Orun or C-R-Z branding. (2) Draft the OSF pre-registration, the consent forms, the 988 safety flow, the partner cap, and the stop rules — and do not recruit anyone until an ethics or IRB review is in hand, typically by partnering with a university lab. (3) Only after the materials are ready, run an informal five-day dry run with three to five friend or colleague pairs. (4) PI decision: whether H5 and the help-seeking measure go into the preregistration. (5) PI decision: whether to run the Section 11.8 solo micro-study (PRMQ, NASA-TLX, Flow Short Scale) or add two unvalidated daily items to the paired study. (6) Optional, personal: fill in "My dials" (Section 10.7) and keep the Accepting Help card (Section 10.10) and the chain card (Section 11.7) with your crisis plan; they are not study material.

File locations.

- This checkpoint (v1.3): `/workspace/research-checkpoint/Checkpoint-v1.3.md` and `Checkpoint-v1.3.pdf`; v1.2 kept as `Checkpoint-v1.2.md` and `.pdf`; v1.1 kept as `Checkpoint-Gemini-Collaboration-v1.1.md` and `.pdf`
- Gemini transcripts: `/workspace/research-checkpoint/gemini-transcript/` (copies of `/workspace/gemini/`)
- Chat: gemini.google.com/app/90c713738868da46

- Version 1.0 papers: `/workspace/research-final/`, live on the mindframe research index
- Novel: `/workspace/novel/`
- Copilot scenes: `/workspace/copilot/replies/`
- C-R-Z paper: `/workspace/crz-framework/`

1.1 What this document is and is not

It is a dated record of a collaboration, a citation audit, a comparison of three proposed studies, and a draft protocol. It is not a new version of the unified framework, not a pre-registration, not an ethics application, and not evidence that any protocol works. Version 1.0 remains the finished statement of the framework. Sections 10 and 11, new in versions 1.2 and 1.3, record further postulates from the PI as a conceptual extension; it is graded the same way and does not alter the draft protocol except for one proposed exploratory measure. Changes recommended here are queued for a later revision of that paper; they are listed in Section 8 so they are not lost.

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2. Provenance

2.1 What was asked

Four prompts were sent to Gemini in a single chat, with the version 1.0 unified PDF and the novel PDF attached to the first prompt.

1. **Peer review.** A rigorous, honest review of Orun Unified Research: Returning to the Living and of how well the novel Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back dramatizes the research: strongest contributions, weakest claims, citations or evidence grades to question, and the novel's fit. Plain bullet points were requested.
2. **Topic-by-topic evidence.** For six themes — a living key versus the solo Drop; attention as a fading, zero-debt currency; mind-wandering and conversational syncing; feelings outlasting memory, in grief and dementia; swappable thinking styles under Universal Design for Learning, not "learning styles"; and fiction and AI roleplay as a test bed — Gemini was asked what current research actually says (naming only studies it was confident exist), the most interesting open question, and one testable idea.
3. **New directions.** Three genuinely new research directions, each with a one-line title, why it matters, a small study an independent researcher could run, the main ethical risk, and the single most important existing paper to read first; then a pick, with reasons.
4. **A 30-day plan.** If Gemini, Grok Bot, and the author worked as co-researchers on the chosen direction, what each should do in the next 30 days, with weekly milestones, plus any overclaims that should be dropped.

The exact prompt text is in `gemini-transcript/prompt1.txt` through `prompt4.txt`.

2.2 Which AI said what

Role	Who	What it contributed	What it did not do
Principal investigator	Ryan Espinosa	Owns the framework, the values layer, ethical oversight, and every final theoretical decision	Has not yet filed ethics materials or recruited participants
Literature, canon, and consistency	Grok Bot	Drafted the v1.0 papers and the novel; sent the four prompts; verified Gemini's citations; wrote this checkpoint; accepted or qualified each review point; recommended folding the Surprise Test into Direction 2	Is not a co-investigator or a source of primary evidence
External review, methods, and adversarial audit	Google Gemini	Peer review (reply 1); topic-by-topic literature comments (reply 2); three directions and a first pick (reply 3); the 30-day plan and overclaims to drop (reply 4)	Did not have access to a Pro model in this session; is not a co-investigator or a source of primary evidence
Earlier scene drafting (novel only)	Microsoft Copilot	Six Orun scenes and co-author notes, used in the novel, not in the research claims	Did not review the unified paper

Gemini's replies are archived, unedited, in `gemini-transcript/reply1.txt` through `reply4.txt`. Some mathematical symbols in those files are duplicated because they were copied from the rendered page. Formulas quoted below have been cleaned to ordinary notation, for example $V(t) = V_0\, e^{-\lambda t}$.

2.3 Model limits

The interface available on 13 November 2026 did not offer Gemini's Pro model. The session ran under the "Everyday help" option. That is a real limit: a stronger model might have been more careful with citations, and two of the papers Gemini named as first readings for Direction 3 could not be found. This checkpoint does not re-run the review on a different model. If a Pro session is run later, its output should be filed beside these transcripts and checked the same way, not treated as automatically better.

Large language models can invent references that look complete. That is why every citation Gemini named was checked against Crossref, publisher pages, or PubMed, and why unverified items are listed as pending rather than silently dropped or replaced. Neither assistant's wording is evidence. Only checked literature, and later data, can support a claim.

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3. Gemini's peer review

Gemini's review was, on the whole, fair, and it lined up with the spirit of version 1.0: retire overclaims, keep values separate, and do not treat a novel as a test. Below, each of its main strengths is recorded, and each of its criticisms is marked **accept**,

partially accept, or **contest**, with a reason. “Accept” means we will act on it. “Partially accept” means the point is right in part, or is already partly handled, and we say what we take and what we do not. No major criticism is contested in full.

3.1 Strengths we accept

- **Epistemic discipline.** Gemini treated the paper’s retirement of earlier overclaims (the foot solar-plexus reflex point, literal v = 0, power-posing hormone effects, “mania glimmers,” and “learning styles” matching) and its separation of empirical claims, design rules, and personal values as the paper’s greatest strength. We agree. That boundary-policing is the standard this checkpoint has to keep.
- **Paired call-and-answer.** It praised the shift from a solitary Reality-Return maneuver to an interpersonal closed loop (“Where are you?” / “Here. Heard.”) as a direct answer to the risk that C-R-Z becomes a closed circuit in which a person only “listens” to silence. We agree. This is why Direction 2 is the load-bearing next study.
- **Rivel as continuing bonds, without hoarding.** It read the rivel rules (credit in the dead person’s name, funding only through active use, consent, and a ban on using the dead to win living arguments), plus the novel’s “living names without living purses,” as a socio-technical translation of Klass, Silverman, and Nickman (1996) and of Stroebe and Schut (1999). We accept that reading as a fair account of the design intent, not as evidence that the design works.
- **Non-punitive incentives.** It noted that a fixed, deterministic morning gift, and the exclusion of inner-state scores from access or payment, push against Goodhart’s law and against variable-ratio engagement loops. We agree, as design intent. The economic claims remain untested.
- **The Surprise Test.** It singled out Kesh’s question, “When did she last surprise you?”, as an intuitive, still unvalidated heuristic for telling a genuine other-voice from a self-generated loop. We agree, and we fold it into the next study as a daily item rather than leaving it only in the novel.

3.2 Criticisms, with our response

C1. The exclusivity clauses in P1, P3, and U8 are empirically indefensible. Gemini argued that claims of the form “only connection completes a purpose” or “honoring people outside the mind is the only way out” cannot be sustained, and that the paper already concedes the point when Tamar finishes the clay work alone. It granted that these are graded Speculative or [Values], but said keeping them in the core postulate list still muddies the water.

Response: **accept.** Version 1.0 already graded the “only” wording as speculative or as conviction. That is not enough. In a later revision of the unified paper, the exclusive wording should leave the proposition list entirely and remain only in the values layer. The empirical restatements can stay: unfinished purposes tend to stay active

until they are completed or released; honoring people outside the mind is a supported route back; love may remain when memory fades, as hope, not as a finding. Tamar's solitary work is a fair counterexample from our own fiction, and it should be cited as such.

C2. The fading-value commons should not be generalized as a macroeconomy. Gemini called the demurrage-plus-zero-floor claim thin, resting on Depression-era anecdotes (Gesell, Fisher, Wörgl) and on Ostrom's principles for physical commons. It warned that continuous exponential decay, $V(t) = V_0\, e^{-\lambda t}$, can create "hot-potato" spending and wash-trading unless friction and review are strong.

Response: **accept.** Version 1.0 already grades U6 as plausible, with thin precedent, and untested. We add the hot-potato and wash-trading failure modes as design risks that Direction 3 would have to measure. We will not speak of macroeconomic generalizability. Wörgl circulation figures remain unverified and must not be used as quantitative support (see Section 4 and Section 11).

C3. Mapping Universal Design for Learning routes onto intergroup contact is a strained leap. Gemini noted that Pettigrew and Tropp (2006) support contact across social groups, not the claim that offering words, pictures, or movement as equal routes reduces prejudice.

Response: **accept**, with one clarification. Version 1.0 already labeled this speculative. We accept that the leap is too strained to keep even as a prejudice-reduction hypothesis in the core list. UDL stays as an accessibility and autonomy design choice. We do not contest the critique; we only note that the paper did not grade this as supported.

C4. Phase B of the v1.0 pilot under-specifies demand characteristics and partner burden. Self-chosen partners introduce selection bias. The protocol did not cap how often one person may call, and a lightweight cue can become reassurance-seeking, which would violate P7.

Response: **accept.** This is the strongest practical criticism, and it is the main reason we adopt Gemini's Direction 2 rather than running the v1.0 Phase B as written. The draft protocol in Section 6 adds a daily cap, a right to decline or delay, a partner-burden item, a content-free window, and equally positive framing of both arms.

C5. Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel (2010) is stretched when it is asked to support "when memories fade, love remains." The study showed that, in five patients with bilateral hippocampal damage, induced sadness and happiness lasted more than 30 minutes after the inducing film had been forgotten. That is not long-term relational permanence, and it is not dementia.

Response: **accept.** Version 1.0 already recorded the small sample and the bidirectional finding. The remaining risk is rhetorical: readers can still take U7 as a scientific stair-step to P6. Feinstein et al. (2010) may support only the narrow claim that some feelings can outlast memory of their cause, in both directions, in this neurological population, over a short interval. It must not be cited for "only love remains," which stays in the values layer.

C6. The motor-interrupt grade blurs two different mechanisms. Articulatory suppression and finger tapping, as in Nalborczyk et al. (2022) and in the working-memory tradition of Baddeley and Hitch (1974), bear on the phonological loop. Dropping the shoulders and shifting weight into the feet are proprioceptive and vestibular. Gemini called the general "brief motor act" grade fair as a plausible neighbor, but not a mechanism for the specific C-R-Z somatic moves.

Response: **accept.** A later revision should split the claim: mouthing or a speech-like motor act as a plausible interrupt of verbal rumination; postural dropping as a separately motivated, still untested, somatic cue. The phonological-loop papers must not be offered as the mechanism for the shoulder-and-feet moves.

C7. Implementation intentions are only a neighbor of "planned absorption with an exit cue," and absorbed states can erase the very meta-awareness the exit needs. Gemini accepted Gollwitzer (1999) as a reasonable theoretical neighbor and added Schooler's (2002) caution that deep absorption or grief loops degrade the noticing that would trigger an if-then exit.

Response: **partially accept.** We keep Gollwitzer (1999) as a neighbor, which is how version 1.0 already cites it, and we accept the added limitation: a pre-set exit cue may fail precisely when it is most needed. That is one reason a living partner, or an external prompt, is worth comparing with a solitary cue. We do not treat Gollwitzer as a study of C-R-Z or of maladaptive daydreaming.

C8. Some secondary citations carried from Coherence Under Decay were still unverified: Ferster and Skinner (1957), Schüll (2012), and the Wörgl figures.

Response: **partially accept.** The demand to verify before any journal submission is accepted in full. As of this checkpoint, Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) have been confirmed on Crossref (see Section 12). The Wörgl figures (turnover multiples, unemployment changes, and similar quantitative claims) are still unverified against a primary source and must not be relied on. The historical episode itself — a local stamp-scrip experiment in Wörgl, Austria, in 1932–1933 — is widely described, but description is not audited data.

C9. The novel's community is too well behaved. Aside from Bram's outsider skepticism and Kesh's brief temptation to forge a border, Gemini saw almost no bad-faith actors, no gaming of the dawn roll, no counterfeit glass, and no free-riding on Mira's surplus bread, so Ostrom's enforcement machinery is never really tested.

Response: **accept**, with a narrow clarification. The clarification is only that the novel is not empty of strain: Neru uses her mother's rivel to block Tamar's clay; Kesh sells unwalked maps; a letter written with care is read as indifference. Those are institutional and interpersonal failures, not adversarial economic ones. Gemini is right that the selu rules are never stress-tested by gaming. That gap belongs in the Novel Analysis and is a reason to keep Direction 3 on the later map, not to treat Orun as evidence for U6.

C10. The fiction also smooths emotional resolutions. The Drop works reliably in high-stakes moments, and Ilun's blunt sentence ("She is dead, Neru") lands without a long defensive rupture.

Response: **accept.** This matches the Novel Analysis already attached to version 1.0, including the observation that the book is kinder than the evidence in several places. A second edition of the novel could roughen those scenes; the research must not take their cleanliness as support.

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4. Topic-by-topic evidence from the second reply

Gemini's second reply is summarized below, topic by topic. Every work it named was checked for this checkpoint. A citation is **verified** if a matching work was found on Crossref, a publisher page, or PubMed, with author, year, and title in agreement. It is **unverified** if no such record was found. Book chapters already flagged in version 1.0 keep their pagination caution. We do not add substitute studies to fill a hole, except that when Gemini named a measure (for example the State Cognitive Fusion Questionnaire, or "UCLA-3") we record the standard source of that measure, clearly marked as a lookup of the instrument, not as a paper Gemini itself cited.

4.1 Living key versus the solo Drop

What Gemini said the literature supports. Solo outward reorienting and grounding have backing as a family of practices, including affect labeling (Lieberman et al. 2007) and brief, exhale-emphasized slow breathing (Zaccaro et al. 2018; Balban et al. 2023). Thought suppression can rebound (Wegner 1994); acceptance and defusion, including "dropping the rope," are the contrasting stance (Hayes, Strosahl, and Wilson 1999). On the interpersonal side, perceived partner responsiveness (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004) and conversational grounding and repair (Clark and Brennan 1991; Schegloff, Jefferson, and Sacks 1977) are established neighbors. Gemini stated, correctly, that there is no direct head-to-head trial of a brief solo somatic-attentional drop against a structured dyadic call-and-answer for breaking rumination.

Open question it posed. When does a living key speed an exit, and when does it become compulsive reassurance-seeking, with meta-awareness outsourced to the partner?

Testable idea. A two-week randomized ecological momentary assessment (EMA) study in adults with daily brooding (Ruminative Responses Scale; Treynor, Gonzalez, and Nolen-Hoeksema 2003), comparing a solo postural drop plus naming three ambient sounds against a paired, non-analytical read-back, with time-to-recovery, affect, and partner burden as outcomes.

Our note. All of the named citations in this topic are verified (Reis, Clark, and Holmes 2004 remains a book chapter whose page range should be spot-checked before quotation). The open question is the right one, and it is why Direction 2, not a simple "living key wins" trial, is the next step. Version 1.0 already graded U5 as plausible for this reason.

4.2 Attention as a fading currency, with a zero-debt floor

What Gemini said. The theoretical roots are Gesell (1916) and Fisher (1933), with thin, confounded precedent in Depression-era scrip, including Wörgl (1932–1933). Community-scale equal-credit systems have a neighbor in time banking (Cahn and Rowe 1992). Durable commons depend on boundaries, local rules, monitoring, and graduated sanctions (Ostrom 1990). Variable-ratio rewards drive compulsive checking (Ferster and Skinner 1957; Schüll 2012).

Open question. In a digital micro-community, does a decaying token with a zero floor foster unhurried exchange, or does it induce hot-potato anxiety and wash-trading?

Testable idea. A four-week closed online micro-economy comparing non-decaying tokens, decaying tokens with a zero floor and a fixed daily gift, and variable-bonus (lottery) tokens, measuring velocity, inequality, contribution quality, and anxiety.

Our note. Gesell (1916), Fisher (1933), Cahn and Rowe (1992), and Ostrom (1990) were already verified in version 1.0. Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012), which version 1.0 had left unverified, are now verified as a book and a monograph respectively. Wörgl figures remain unverified. This topic is the background for Direction 3, which we are not running first.

4.3 Mind-wandering and conversational syncing

What Gemini said. People spend a large share of waking time mind-wandering, with a reliable association to lower momentary happiness (Killingsworth and Gilbert 2010). Intentional and unintentional wandering differ (Seli, Risko, and Smilek 2016), as do experiential drift and meta-awareness (Schooler 2002; Smallwood and Schooler 2015). Task switching has measurable costs that cues can reduce (Monsell 2003; Rubinstein, Meyer, and Evans 2001). Doorways act as event boundaries (Radvansky, Krawietz, and Tamplin 2011). A visible phone degrades perceived closeness (Przybylski and Weinstein 2013). Active-constructive responding (Gable et al. 2004) and explicit repair (Schegloff et al. 1977) help restore alignment.

Open question. Can a socially normal “repair script” (naming the drift, then a one-line read-back) remove the social penalty of a lapse and reduce the switch cost of re-entering the conversation?

Testable idea. A laboratory dyadic conversation in which one partner is covertly distracted, comparing naturalistic recovery, silent re-engagement, and explicit repair plus read-back, with perceived responsiveness and recall as outcomes.

Our note. Every citation in this topic is verified. The laboratory idea is coherent and could later serve as a mechanistic companion to the field study. It is not the first study we will run.

4.4 Feelings outlasting memory, in grief and dementia

What Gemini said. Feinstein, Duff, and Tranel (2010) is the landmark small study, bidirectional over a short interval. Grief research has moved toward continuing bonds (Klass, Silverman, and Nickman 1996) and the Dual Process Model (Stroebe and Schut 1999). Impairing, persistent yearning is classified as prolonged grief disorder in DSM-5-TR (American Psychiatric Association 2022).

Open question. In progressive dementias, how long does the emotional valence of a visit last, and can a warm, non-quizzing presence leave a positive residue after episodic recall of the visit is gone?

Testable idea. An observational care-facility protocol comparing task-focused visits with warm relational presence, measuring affect, agitation, and arousal at 15, 45, and 90 minutes.

Our note. All named citations are verified. The dementia protocol is ethically heavier than anything we should attempt without a clinical and institutional partner. We record it as a later, specialist direction. It must not be used to stretch Feinstein et al. (2010) any further (see C5).

4.5 Swappable thinking styles, UDL, and “learning styles”

What Gemini said. The meshing hypothesis for fixed learning styles lacks support (Pashler, McDaniel, Rohrer, and Bjork 2008). Universal Design for Learning (CAST 2024) offers unranked means of engagement, representation, and action. Pettigrew and Tropp (2006) support intergroup contact as a route to lower prejudice; there is no evidence that swappable reflective modalities do the same.

Open question. Does a free, unranked menu of regulation routes improve adherence and self-efficacy compared with a single protocol or a once-assessed “style match,” and does practicing someone else’s preferred route foster cognitive empathy?

Testable idea. A three-arm digital stress-regulation trial: fixed text/logic steps; a style-matched assignment; and a swappable UDL menu.

Our note. All named citations are verified. We accept Gemini's separation of UDL from contact theory (C3). A UDL menu can still be how the Return Card is offered, without any claim about prejudice.

4.6 Fiction and AI roleplay as a test bed

What Gemini said. Narrative transportation can temporarily suspend counterarguing (Green and Brock 2000). People apply social heuristics to mediated personas (Horton and Wohl 1956). Immersive fantasy can become maladaptive daydreaming when it replaces ordinary functioning (Somer 2002). Simulated worlds are useful for hypothesis generation, but an author who controls the ending cannot validate causality.

Open question. Can structured adversarial roleplay with a language model — skeptical, outsider, or edge-case personas — expose failure modes before human trials?

Testable idea. Compare solo revision of early-stage behavioral proposals with adversarial narrative simulation, rated blind by independent scientists for blind-spot identification and falsifiability.

Our note. The three named citations are verified. This is, in effect, a description of what we already did with Copilot and Gemini. It can generate designs and objections. It cannot replace measurement, and we will not treat this checkpoint, or the novel, as a completed test of that method.

4.7 Citations Gemini named that did not hold up, or that needed a name correction

These belong with the later directions (Section 5) but are recorded here because they surfaced as "existing papers to read first":

- **Godschalk (2012)** is verified. Hugo Godschalk, "Does demurrage matter for complementary currencies?", International Journal of Community Currency Research 16(D), 58–69. The journal's web header sometimes prints the name as "Godshalk," but the article byline, the requested citation, and the author's address (`hgodschalk@paysys.de`) all use Godschalk. DOI 10.15133/j.ijccr.2012.012 (the journal site resolves; Crossref did not return a work record for this DOI on the check date).
- **Champ, Freeman, and Weber (2003)**, offered as an experimental or theoretical paper on depreciating currency, is **unverified**. No 2003 paper by those three authors on demurrage was found. Champ, Freeman, and Weber (1999) is a paper on note redemption under the U.S. National Banking System, not on demurrage. Champ's relevant commentary on stamp scrip is later and sole-authored (Champ 2008, noted only as a lead; it is not used as evidence here because Gemini did not name it correctly, and we are not substituting a repaired citation into Gemini's list).

- **Ikkatai et al. (2023)**, offered as “experimental studies on depreciating currency (demurrage) and circulation velocity,” is **unverified**. No matching paper was found. A later Bank of Japan working paper by Kota Ikkatai and colleagues (2024) is about unconventional monetary policy and the yen, not demurrage, and is not a substitute.

Until a primary source is produced, those two items stay in the pending list and must not appear in participant materials, pre-registrations, or any public claim.

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5. The three proposed directions

Gemini proposed three directions and picked Direction 2. We agree with that pick, and we fold Direction 1 into it as a daily EMA item rather than running it as a standalone first study.

	Direction 1. The Surprise Test	**Direction 2. Dyadic Read-Back (chosen)**	**Direction 3. Demurrage stress test**
One-line title	Does a “lack of surprise” mark, and can it interrupt, a self-generated inner voice?	When does a content-free check-in co-regulate without co-rumination or partner burnout?	Does a decaying, zero-floor token invite generosity or hot-potato gaming?
Why it matters	The novel’s sharpest new heuristic has never been tested.	It is the load-bearing test of U5, and it guards the main real-world failure mode of “use a person as your key.”	Orun’s economy has never been run with real actors; U6 should not be built into an app until it is.
Sketch of a study	10-day EMA micro-randomization, 60–80 adults with ordinary brooding; surprise-test prompt on half of imagined-conversation episodes.	3-week field RCT, 40–50 dyads; constrained read-back versus unconstrained supportive check-in.	14-day online communities, 90–120 people; fixed tokens versus demurrage versus demurrage with a slower “rest” decay.
Main ethical risk	In bereavement, labeling a comforting voice as “only my mind” can cause a secondary drop. Needs briefing and a mood-repair close.	Relational asymmetry and emotional labor. Needs a daily cap and a right to decline.	Cash conversion can distort giving and create real financial stress. Tokens should not cash out; participation pay should be flat.
First paper named	Alderson-Day and Fernyhough (2015) — **verified**	Zaki and Williams (2013), with Rose (2002) — **both verified**	Godschalk (2012) — **verified**; Ikkatai (2023) and Champ, Freeman, and Weber (2003) — **unverified**
Our decision	Fold into Direction 2 as a daily item, not the first standalone trial.	**Chosen.** Draft protocol in Section 6.	Keep on the later map. Do not start until Direction 2 is either running under ethics review or has been fairly abandoned.

Gemini's reasons for picking Direction 2 still hold. It tests the central open claim of the unified paper. It confronts the failure mode that would harm the very relationships the framework is meant to protect. It is smaller, cheaper, and more clearly falsifiable than a token economy, and it does not require building a platform first.

Our one change is inexpensive and on-theme: add a daily Surprise Test item to the same EMA, so Direction 1 is not lost and does not compete for a separate sample. A later micro-randomized prompt can be added if the daily item looks promising. We also add an ethics gate that Gemini's 30-day calendar understated: real participants wait on formal review.

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6. The chosen direction: a draft protocol (not final)

This section is a working draft for later pre-registration. It is not locked, not ethics-approved, and not a treatment trial. Until an institutional review is complete, the only human use of these materials should be an informal dry run with consenting friends or colleagues who are told that it is a materials test, not a study.

6.1 Question and hypotheses

Question. In adults with ordinary (non-clinical) brooding, does a strictly constrained, content-free dyadic read-back reduce brooding without increasing partner burden, compared with an ordinary supportive check-in?

Draft hypotheses, all pre-registerable, all allowed to fail:

- **H1 (primary).** The constrained read-back arm will show a larger reduction, or at least no smaller reduction, in brooding on the Ruminative Responses Scale than the unconstrained supportive arm.
- **H2 (co-primary or key secondary).** The constrained arm will show lower partner-reported burden, and lower daily co-rumination, than the unconstrained arm.
- **H3 (secondary).** Perceived partner responsiveness will not be meaningfully worse in the constrained arm (a non-inferiority question; the exact margin is to be set at pre-registration).
- **H4 (exploratory).** On days when a participant notices that an imagined voice did not surprise them, or when they use the Surprise Test item, subsequent rumination will be lower, or defusion higher, than on days when an inner conversation is reported as still surprising. This is not a third randomized arm.

A finding that the arms do not differ on brooding, or that the constrained arm raises burden or lowers responsiveness, would count against a simple reading of U5 and would be reported as such.

6.2 The two arms

Participants. About 40–50 adult dyads (romantic partners, close friends, or housemates) in which at least one person reports frequent worry or brooding. Both members consent. This is a feasibility size, not a powered confirmatory sample; a power target belongs in the OSF pre-registration.

Inclusion and exclusion (draft). Adults; ordinary, non-clinical brooding. Exclude acute crisis, current mania or psychosis, and active prolonged grief disorder. That last group needs its own clinical study. Anyone who becomes unsafe during the study is withdrawn and referred.

Duration. Three weeks of field use, with pre- and post-measures, plus a brief baseline and exit questionnaire.

Arm A — Constrained call-and-answer. When either person notices drift or looping, they may start a short, procedural exchange only: “Where are you?” / “Here. Heard.” The person who was looping then names one physical object in the room (or in view). The pair does not discuss the content of the worry for 15 minutes. The script may be used in person or by voice; text is a fallback, not the preferred channel.

Arm B — Unconstrained supportive check-in. When either person notices drift or looping, they check in and may talk through whatever is on their mind, in whatever way they already offer support. No content window, no fixed script.

Both arms must be described, in every participant-facing sentence, as two reasonable communication habits. No sentence may say that the read-back is expected to work better, to “cure” or “stop” rumination, or to test a named philosophy.

6.3 Measures

Licensing and official forms are still to be confirmed before any use (this is a Week 1 task). Draft set:

Measure	Role	Source status
Ruminative Responses Scale, brooding items	Primary pre/post outcome	Treynor, Gonzalez, and Nolen-Hoeksema (2003), verified; license and exact item set to be confirmed
Perceived Partner Responsiveness Scale	Secondary, both members	Conceptual neighbor: Reis, Clark, and Holmes (2004), already in v1.0, pagination caution. The scale chapter is Reis, Crasta, Rogge, Maniaci, and Carmichael (2017/2018), looked up as the instrument source, verified on Crossref
Daily partner-burden item (responding partner)	Key secondary	Gemini named a “Partner Burden & Resentment scale” but did not give a source. **No instrument is invented here.** The item wording is an open decision (Section 9)
Daily co-rumination frequency	Key secondary	Rose (2002) is the construct source, verified; her full questionnaire was built for youth friendships and would need an adult, daily adaptation, to be specified later

Measure	Role	Source status
Surprise Test item (daily EMA)	Exploratory (H4)	Novel-derived; unvalidated. Draft wording: “If you had an imagined conversation today, did the other voice say anything you did not already expect? If never, can you label it as your own voice in their cadence?”
SWEMWBS (7-item Warwick–Edinburgh)	Secondary well-being	Tennant et al. (2007); Stewart-Brown et al. (2009), both verified. Registration or license terms must be confirmed before use
UCLA-3 loneliness	Secondary	**Naming conflict, logged as an open decision.** Version 1.0 specified the 20-item UCLA Loneliness Scale, Version 3 (Russell 1996), verified. “UCLA-3” often means the 3-item short form (Hughes, Waite, Hawkley, and Cacioppo 2004), looked up as the usual referent of that name and verified. For a field study, the 3-item form is the lighter option; the 20-item form may still be used at baseline. Pick one and pre-register it
Feasibility	Use, answer rate, drop-off	Study-log counts, not a published scale
Optional, only if Direction 1 is later expanded	State Cognitive Fusion Questionnaire	Gemini named the instrument for a standalone Surprise Test study. The validation paper is Bolderston, Gillanders, Turner, Taylor, Ní Mhaoileoin, and Coleman (2019), looked up as the instrument source, verified. Not required for the first draft of Direction 2

6.4 Safety, 988, stop rules, and the partner cap

- **Crisis information.** Every participant and every partner receives the 988 notice at consent, at weekly contact, and at exit. If someone is in immediate danger, they are told to call 911. This study is not a crisis service and must not present itself as one.
- **Stop rules (draft).** Pre-set worsening of distress; emerging mania or psychosis signs; any safety concern raised by a participant, a partner, or the investigator; or a partner-burden threshold to be fixed at pre-registration. Any of these triggers withdrawal of the dyad and a referral, not a request to “try the card again.”
- **Partner cap.** No more than two initiated check-ins per day per dyad, unless both people freely offer more. The responding partner may decline or delay without penalty and without having to explain the day’s worry. That right is written into both consents.
- **Content-free window (Arm A only).** The 15-minute bar on rehashing the worry is a protection against co-rumination, not a gag rule about safety. If someone is in danger, the window does not apply.
- **“Drop everything” limits.** The author’s P5 language, “drop everything for a real conversation,” is a values statement. In the protocol it is bounded by safety, consent, the partner’s right to decline, work and caregiving duties, and the participant’s own needs. The study must never instruct people to ignore those bounds.

6.5 Neutral framing and what participants must not see

Participant materials will not use the words selu, eshva, rivel, Orun, C-R-Z, Zero-Velocity, Returning to the Living, or "living key," and will not include the novel, the unified paper, or a statement that connection is the only way out. The study is framed as a comparison of two communication habits: a short structured check-in, and an open supportive check-in. U5 may be the investigators' hypothesis; it is not a fact to be taught to the people being asked to test it.

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7. The 30-day plan

Roles follow Gemini's division, with one correction. Ryan Espinosa, as PI, owns ethics, recruitment, consent, safety, and final theoretical decisions. Grok Bot handles literature verification, alignment with the existing Return Card, and plain-language drafts. Gemini (in a later session) is asked to handle a pre-registration blueprint, a synthetic-data analysis script, and an audit of demand characteristics. Neither assistant is a co-investigator.

Ethics gate. Gemini's Week 4 opened recruitment. That is too fast if a university review is not done. The plan below keeps the weekly shape but makes recruitment conditional on approval. If approval is not in hand by Day 22, Week 4 becomes a freeze-and-wait week, not a launch.

Week 1. Pre-registration and protocol lock (Days 1–7)

- ☐ **Ryan:** Write exact inclusion and exclusion criteria, and finalize the 988 referral flow and the partner-decline language.
- ☐ **Grok:** Confirm licensing and official item wording for RRS, PPRS, SWEMWBS, and the chosen loneliness measure; format the two-arm pocket/phone instructions in plain language.
- ☐ **Gemini:** Draft an OSF pre-registration (sample-size reasoning, primary and secondary endpoints, the partner-burden threshold, and stop rules).
- ☐ **Shared:** Resolve the open decisions in Section 9 that block a lock (loneliness measure, burden item, whether v1.0 Phase A stays in the program).

Week 2. Instrumentation, ethics, and simulation (Days 8–14)

- ☐ **Ryan:** Identify an ethics or IRB path, preferably with a university lab; submit only when the protocol is stable. Set up a minimal-identifier survey or EMA pipeline.
- ☐ **Grok:** Draft plain-language consents for the primary participant and the partner, with no Orun or C-R-Z vocabulary.
- ☐ **Gemini:** Write a reproducible analysis script against synthetic dyadic data, before any real data exist.

Week 3. Dry-run of materials and an adversarial pass (Days 15–21)

- ☐ **Ryan:** Run a five-day informal dry run with three to five volunteer pairs who are not formal research participants, to test friction, timing, and the no-rehashing rule.
- ☐ **Grok:** Collect qualitative friction notes and revise onboarding where pairs slip into problem-solving or co-rumination.
- ☐ **Gemini:** Audit the dry-run copy so that Arm B is framed as positively and credibly as Arm A.

Week 4. Only if ethics approval is in hand (Days 22–30)

- ☐ **Ryan:** If and only if review is approved, open recruitment toward 40–50 dyads, take consent from both members, and collect baseline measures. If review is not approved, do not recruit; file the frozen protocol and wait.
- ☐ **Grok:** Keep a version-controlled study log and watch completion rates.
- ☐ **Gemini:** If data collection has legally started, run automated balance and data-quality checks. If it has not, stop at the synthetic-data rehearsal.

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8. Overclaims to retire, and the updates needed in version 1.0

Gemini listed four overclaims to drop before any launch. We accept all four, and we add the manuscript edits they imply.

In every participant-facing document, drop:

1. Any premise that a “living key” is already known to be superior. U5 is a hypothesis.
2. Any claim that a read-back “cures,” “stops,” or reliably breaks rumination. It is an attentional and conversational cue. It may fail, and it may feel intrusive.
3. Any universal wording of the form “only connection completes a purpose” or “only love remains.” Those belong in the values layer, not in a study.
4. All C-R-Z and Orun branding, including the novel, selu, eshva, rivel, and Zero-Velocity.

Queued edits for a later revision of the unified paper (version 1.0 stays the finished conceptual snapshot; these are the deltas):

1. Move the exclusive wording of P1, P3, and U8 out of the core proposition list and leave it only in the values layer (C1).
2. State the hot-potato and wash-trading risks under U6, and drop any hint of macroeconomic generalizability (C2).
3. Remove the mapping of UDL routes onto Pettigrew and Tropp’s contact theory as a prejudice-reduction path; keep UDL as accessibility (C3).

4. Replace v1.0 Phase B with this Direction 2 draft, including the partner cap, the decline right, the burden item, and the content-free window (C4). Keep Phase A (laboratory solo Drop versus control) only if the PI still wants it; that is an open decision.
5. Narrow the Feinstein et al. (2010) citation so that it cannot be read as support for "love remains" (C5).
6. Split the motor-interrupt claim into a phonological-loop neighbor and a separate, untested postural cue (C6).
7. Add Schooler's meta-awareness caution to the "planned absorption with an exit cue" line (C7).
8. Note that Ferster and Skinner (1957) and Schüll (2012) are now verified, and that Wörgl figures are still not (C8).
9. Keep the Novel Analysis's list of places where the fiction is kinder than the evidence, including weak adversarial testing of the commons (C9, C10).
10. Record this checkpoint, the Gemini chat, and the chosen direction in the program history.

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9. Open questions and a decision log

9.1 Open questions

1. Which university or institutional partner will provide ethics review, and on what timeline?
2. What are the exact license terms for RRS, PPRS, and SWEMWBS?
3. Loneliness measure: Russell (1996) Version 3 (20 items), Hughes et al. (2004) 3-item form, or 20 items at baseline and 3 items daily?
4. What is the exact daily partner-burden item? Gemini named a scale that we could not identify from the reply. Do not invent a titled instrument.
5. Does version 1.0 Phase A (laboratory solo Drop versus a still-sitting or counting control) remain in the program, move later, or get dropped?
6. Should a later micro-randomization of the Surprise Test prompt be added inside Direction 2, or is a daily item enough for now?
7. When, if ever, to run Direction 3, and with what non-cash redemption design?
8. Should the Gemini review be repeated on a Pro model, and if so, how will disagreements with this checkpoint be reconciled?
9. Who, besides the PI, can see identifiable dry-run notes?
10. Should H5 (help-seeking intentions, GHSQ) enter the pre-registration, and which sources should the adapted GHSQ list?
11. Should the Accepting Help card and the Universal Variables be tested later as their own study (for example, whether setting personal dials improves help-seeking or self-concept clarity), and with what measures?

12. Can a primary copy of Rosenberg and McCullough (1981) be located so that the original mattering source can be cited directly?
13. Does the PI accept the working reading of the action–thought chain in Section 11.2, or should it be restated?
14. Should the solo micro-study (Section 11.8) run before, alongside, or after the paired study?

9.2 Decision log

Date	Decision	Status
13 November 2026	Version 1.0 of the unified paper is the finished conceptual framework. Further progress is measurement, not a new theory.	Locked in v1.0
13 November 2026	Gemini, under the Everyday help model, reviews the paper and the novel and proposes three directions.	Done; transcripts filed
13 November 2026	Adopt Direction 2 as the next empirical step. Fold Direction 1 in as a daily Surprise Test item. Keep Direction 3 for later.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Real participants require ethics or IRB review, typically with a university lab. Until then, only an informal dry run with friends or colleagues.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Keep Orun and C-R-Z branding out of all participant materials. Frame both arms neutrally.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Ikkatai (2023) and Champ, Freeman, and Weber (2003) are unverified and must not be cited as evidence. Godschalk (2012) is the verified first reading for later demurrage work.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Faith claims, including “only love remains” and “connection takes priority,” stay in the values layer. The 988 notice stays in every public document.	**Decided**
13 November 2026	Week 4 recruitment is conditional on ethics approval.	**Decided** (revision of Gemini’s calendar)
13 November 2026	Add the Accepting-Help Postulate (A1–A16), Universal Variables, and the Accepting Help card as Section 10 (v1.2). Physics terms such as non-locality are metaphor or faith only; mania safety and 988 are stated.	**Decided** (v1.2)
13 November 2026	Propose the GHSQ as an exploratory help-seeking measure (H5); arms and primary outcome unchanged.	**Proposed**, PI to decide
13 November 2026	Add Section 11, the Local Action–Thought Chain (v1.3). The drive to close loops is framed, at the PI’s correction, as purpose-driven willpower kept harmonious, not as OCD; a short boundary note says when to see a professional.	**Decided** (v1.3)
—	Loneliness measure, burden item, and the fate of Phase A.	**Open**

Date	Decision	Status
—	File an ethics application; start Week 1 tasks.	**Not started** (this checkpoint was written first)

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10. The Accepting-Help Postulate: Ending the Inner Story

Added in version 1.2 (13 November 2026). This section records a new postulate from the PI, restates it as numbered sub-postulates, cross-references each one, grades the evidence, and turns it into a practical card and a set of adjustable “dials” that anyone can set for themselves. It is a conceptual extension, not a finding. The draft study in Section 6 is unchanged except for one proposed exploratory measure (Section 10.9).

10.1 The postulate, in the author’s words

The PI’s statement is preserved in full, unedited, as given on 13 November 2026, together with three follow-up lines given the same day:

> apply the mind frame of of a living person to accept help in the first place by using the novel an internal story has to be solved and ended from techniques derived from fiction learned from completing the story an inner language of rules and regulations to be rejected for thou shall not swear on earth heaven or anything but just believe. what snapped me out of guilt and self unforgiveness are the people who sustained my basic surviving instincts while i dealt with mania; fantasy thoughts that took me out of it was radical shamelessness acceptance that everything I will accomplish in this world is based on awareness on my immediate position and environment not depending on memory or personal genius; the greatest discoveries are just everyday life; no one can remember what they don’t understand; eureka is not a stroke of a finished solution but something out of continuous skepticism; God is always with me my Jesus Christ who is non locality; I believe the first place of existence puts you in a local destiny that pulls you back to reality like an equation yet thoughts are non local but everything is bound by time and position so why coveted spur moment ideas and thinking like it will never come back for thoughts are influenced by the environment like an artist the masterpiece is the artist for every last creation of the artist or the most recent model of the artist will produce the best by reacting to self and environment to regain memories and skills; no matter how ridiculous personal belief is whether true or not is needed to have a reference to grow; using these techniques will open up a gate of sustained learning without burnout and still function in society; worship your thoughts and you will be a prisoner to your thoughts

Follow-up lines, verbatim:

> cross check my techniques and my story to find alternate variables that can apply to everyone to get out of their head while maintaining the confidence of identity fight the void of uselessness and using the minimum energy to think and max energy to participate in communication and reality
> no one can save you except yourself

Safety first: read before using anything in this section

Mania is a medical condition. It is part of bipolar disorder and related conditions, and it is treated by clinicians, usually with medication, monitoring, and a relapse-prevention plan. Nothing in this section treats mania, and nothing here replaces professional care, prescribed medication, or the support people around you. These techniques are meant to sit alongside that care.

"Radical shamelessness" means freedom from toxic shame — the global verdict "I am bad." It does not mean ignoring consequences, apologies, repair, or warning signs. Guilt about a specific act, followed by repair, is healthy.

"Minimum energy to think" means not overthinking. It never means shutting down judgment, skipping medication decisions, or ignoring warning signs.

"No one can save you except yourself" never means refusing help, going without professional care, or blaming yourself for needing support. Agency includes the choice to reach out.

The feeling of uselessness is not a fact about your worth. If it comes with thoughts of not wanting to live, call or text **988** (U.S.) now. In immediate danger, call **911**.

Early-warning signs of mania or hypomania (personal signs vary; agree yours with your clinician and support people): sleeping much less without feeling tired; racing thoughts or speech that others find hard to follow; unusual spending, risk-taking, or big sudden plans; feeling unusually special, chosen, or certain; irritability; losing interest in sleep, food, or other people's input. When your signs appear, use your written **crisis or relapse plan**: contact your prescriber or care team, tell your support person, protect sleep, and postpone major decisions. Early-warning-sign plans have evidence (Perry et al. 1999; Morriss et al. 2007). For suicidal crises, a written safety plan is a recognized brief intervention (Stanley and Brown 2012).

10.2 The sub-postulates, restated

Each sub-postulate is credited to Ryan Espinosa and restated in plain words by Grok Bot. Where the wording is the PI’s own, it is quoted.

#	Sub-postulate (plain words)
A1	**Accept help first.** Before any technique, let a living person in. The mind frame of a living person is to receive help; receiving is the first move, not a last resort.
A2	**Only you can walk through** (paired with A1). “No one can save you except yourself.” Others can sustain you, hold the door, and offer a key; only you can choose to walk through it. Choosing to reach out is itself an act of agency.
A3	**End the inner story the way you finish a fiction.** An inner loop is an unfinished story. It has to be solved and ended, using the moves a writer learns by completing a story: name what the scene is really about, let a living character say the true line, and let the protagonist make her own choice.
A4	**Reject the inner rulebook.** Drop the private language of rules, vows, and conditions (“I must,” “I swear I’ll never,” “if I don’t, then…”). Do not bind yourself by oath; “just believe.”
A5	**The people who sustained survival were the turning point.** What broke the cycle of guilt and self-unforgiveness during mania was not an insight but people who kept basic survival going: food, sleep, safety, presence.
A6	**Radical shameless acceptance.** Accept yourself without the verdict of toxic shame, while still owning specific actions and repairing harm.
A7	**Awareness of position, not memory or genius.** What you accomplish rests on awareness of your immediate position and environment — where you are, who is here, what is in front of you — not on remembered brilliance.
A8	**The greatest discoveries are everyday life.** Discovery is found in ordinary, present life, not reserved for exceptional moments.
A9	**You cannot remember what you do not understand.** Understanding comes before durable memory. Chasing an idea you have not understood will not hold it.
A10	**Eureka comes from continuous skepticism.** Insight is not a finished solution that strikes; it grows out of steady questioning, preparation, and rest.
A11	**Local destiny, passing thoughts: do not covet the idea.** One’s place in time and space pulls one back to reality; thoughts feel unbounded but arise from a time and place, and the environment will prompt them again. So do not cling to a sudden idea as though it will never return.
A12	**The masterpiece is the artist.** The latest self is the one who can make the next work. Skill and memory are regained by acting and reacting to self and environment, not by mourning a past peak.
A13	**Belief as a reference point for growth.** A personal belief, however it looks to others, gives a reference point to grow from.
A14	**Sustained learning without burnout.** These practices aim to open “a gate of sustained learning” while still functioning in society.
A15	**“Worship your thoughts and you will be a prisoner to your thoughts.”** Treat thoughts as events to notice, not commands to obey or idols to serve.
A16 (A-final)	**Minimum to think, maximum to take part.** Fight the void of uselessness by spending the least energy needed on thinking and the most on taking part in communication and shared reality.

10.3 The dialectic of A1 and A2: accept help, and walk through yourself

A1 and A2 look opposed. They are a pair. The resolution, stated as the PI’s design principle:

> **Others can sustain you, hold the door open, and offer a key. Only you can choose to walk through.**

This is the same shape as Orun's hardest rule, "People come home only by their own choice." In the novel, Sareth keeps that rule for two seasons while Ren is across the river, and Vethan's return is hers alone. She has Neru's letters and Ila's company, but she says, "I didn't come because your letters talked me into it… I came because I wanted to. And I'm not promising to stay." Neru lets the urge to bargain pass and answers, "You don't have to." At the house door Vethan stops "as if the threshold were a gate that would not open for shouting," Neru does not push, and Vethan herself takes down the fourth cup and sets it on the board (Chapter XVII). The others held the door; she walked through it. No one carried her, and no one left her alone either.

The research fits the pair better than either half. Self-determination theory treats **autonomy** and **relatedness** as basic needs that work together, not as rivals: people thrive when they act from their own choice and feel connected (Ryan and Deci 2000). **Self-efficacy** — confidence that one can carry out a needed action — predicts whether people start and persist in change (Bandura 1977). The personal-recovery literature names **empowerment** (personal responsibility, control) alongside **connectedness** (support from others) in the CHIME framework: Connectedness, Hope, Identity, Meaning, Empowerment (Leamy et al. 2011). Recovery, in that synthesis, is something a person does, with others.

Safety line. "Only you can save you" never means refusing help, refusing professional care, or blaming yourself for needing support. Picking up the phone, taking medication, and saying "I receive it" are exercises of agency, not its surrender.

10.4 Cross-references and evidence grades

Grades follow the program's tiers: **Supported** (consistent published evidence for the stated form), **Plausible** (adjacent evidence; untested in this form), **Speculative** (no direct evidence or contrary evidence), and **[Values]** (the author's conviction; not testable as stated). Every source cited here was checked on 13 November 2026 (Section 12). "C-R-Z" refers to Calibration, Reality-Return, and Zero-Velocity; P1–P7 to the Connection Postulate; U1–U8 to the unified propositions of version 1.0; "Study" to the Section 6 draft.

#	Cross-references	Evidence and grade
A1	P3, P5; U1, U5; C-R-Z Reality-Return (the key comes from outside); Study: tests a structured way to receive a check-in	**Supported** that social support buffers stress (Cohen and Wills 1985) and that relationships predict health (Holt-Lunstad et al. 2010). **Supported** that stigma and self-stigma are real barriers to help-seeking (Corrigan, Larson, and Rüsch 2009; Gulliver, Griffiths, and Christensen 2010; Clement et al. 2015). "First, before any technique" as an ordering rule: **Plausible**.

#	Cross-references	Evidence and grade
A2	P7; U3; Orun's own-choice rule; Study: the right to decline, and the participant chooses to initiate	**Supported** that autonomy and relatedness are joint needs (Ryan and Deci 2000), that self-efficacy predicts change (Bandura 1977), and that empowerment and connectedness are core recovery processes (Leamy et al. 2011). Literal "no one except yourself": **[Values]**; read as solitary self-rescue it is contradicted by the same literature.
A3	P1 (unfinished purposes stay active); P2 (fantasy connects and traps); U8; Novel Analysis	**Supported** that expressive writing has small average benefits (Pennebaker and Beall 1986; Frattaroli 2006, meta-analysis, small effect). **Supported** (correlational) that coherent, redemptive life stories go with well-being (McAdams and McLean 2013). Narrative therapy's "re-authoring" (White and Epston 1990) is an established clinical approach with a thin trial base: **Plausible**. Using fiction-craft moves to end a personal loop: **Speculative**, testable.
A4	P4 (check the facts); U3; C-R-Z Zero-Velocity (let go, do not suppress)	Rigid, fused rule-following is a target in ACT (Hayes et al. 2006); defusion briefly lowers the believability and discomfort of negative self-thoughts (Masuda et al. 2004): **Plausible** as applied here. Matthew 5:34–37 ("Swear not at all… let your communication be, Yea, yea; Nay, nay"): **[Values]**. Rejecting an inner rulebook is not rejecting ethics, law, or a treatment plan.
A5	P3, P5; U1, U5; Study: partner burden is measured because sustainers carry a load	**Supported** that social support predicts recovery from bipolar depressive episodes (Johnson et al. 1999). A follow-up found support and self-esteem predicted changes in bipolar depression **but not mania** (Johnson et al. 2000), so the claim that people pull someone out of mania itself is **not supported** as stated; what is supported is that support people help with early-warning plans and getting care (Perry et al. 1999; Morriss et al. 2007). The PI's own experience is testimony, recorded with respect, not data.
A6	P4; U3; C-R-Z Calibration (notice without verdict)	**Supported** that shame (global self-condemnation) differs from guilt (about an act) (Tangney et al. 1996), and that self-compassion is associated with less psychopathology (MacBeth and Gumley 2012, meta-analysis). Compassion-focused training for high shame: **Plausible** (pilot, Gilbert and Procter 2006). Self-forgiveness is healthiest when paired with responsibility (Hall and Fincham 2005, review): **Plausible**. The word "shamelessness": **[Values]**, reframed as freedom from toxic shame.
A7	C-R-Z Reality-Return; U2, U4; P7	**Plausible.** Outward grounding has support as a family (U2; Hammond and Brown 2025). Context-dependent memory is classic (Godden and Baddeley 1975), but a 2021 replication did **not** find the effect (Murre 2021), so it is weaker than often taught. "Not genius": deliberate practice explains a meaningful but minority share of skill differences (Ericsson, Krampe, and Tesch-Römer 1993; Macnamara, Hambrick, and Oswald 2014), so "practice and position, not innate genius alone" is fair; "never memory" is too strong.
A8	P7; U4	**[Values]** as stated. Adjacent: insight usually follows preparation in ordinary work (Kounios and Beeman 2014).
A9	P7; U4; Study: card wording kept simple so it is understood, not memorized	**Supported** in the form "understanding strongly improves memory": deeper, meaning-based processing yields better retention (Craik and Lockhart 1972), and passages are recalled far better when the reader has the context to understand them (Bransford and Johnson 1972). "No one can remember" literally is too absolute (rote memory exists).

#	Cross-references	Evidence and grade
A10	P7; the Surprise Test (Direction 1) as a skepticism habit	**Plausible.** Incubation reliably, though modestly, helps problem solving (Sio and Ormerod 2009, meta-analysis); insight has measurable antecedents rather than arriving from nowhere (Kounios and Beeman 2014); Wallas (1926) is the classic preparation–incubation–illumination–verification model. "Continuous skepticism" as the engine: **Plausible**, with the caution that endless doubt can become rumination (A15).
A11	C-R-Z Zero-Velocity; P7; U4; CUD paper (by analogy only)	Psychological core — ideas are cued by context and need not be clung to; write it down and return to the room — **Plausible** (context cueing, with the Murre 2021 caution; implementation intentions, Gollwitzer 1999). "Local destiny like an equation" and "thoughts are non-local": **metaphor and [Values]**, not physics (see 10.5).
A12	U4; C-R-Z Calibration; the novel's keeper of the rack	**Plausible.** Skill is maintained and regained through practice with feedback (Ericsson et al. 1993, qualified by Macnamara et al. 2014). "The most recent model of the artist will produce the best": **Speculative** if taken literally (illness, fatigue, and age can lower performance); **[Values]** as "the current self is the one who can act."
A13	Values layer; P5; Study: neutral framing (participants' beliefs are not graded)	**Supported** that affirming one's core values buffers threat and defensiveness (Steele 1988; Cohen and Sherman 2014). "Whether true or not": **[Values]**. Caution: during mania, a belief that is growing in certainty or grandiosity is a warning sign to check with others, not a reference point.
A14	U4, U6 (rest that still fades a little); P5 limits	**Supported** that burnout is a real syndrome of exhaustion, cynicism, and reduced efficacy (Maslach, Schaufeli, and Leiter 2001), and that psychological detachment and relaxation aid recovery from strain (Sonnentag and Fritz 2007). That these techniques prevent burnout: **Speculative**, testable.
A15	U3; P2, P4; C-R-Z Zero-Velocity; Study: SCFQ is optional	**Supported** that cognitive fusion is associated with distress (Gillanders et al. 2014) and that defusion lowers the believability of self-critical thoughts in the short term (Masuda et al. 2004). **Supported** that brooding rumination worsens mood and problem solving (Nolen-Hoeksema, Wisco, and Lyubomirsky 2008), with the nuance that some repetitive thought is constructive (Watkins 2008). "Worship": **[Values]** image.
A16	Eshva; Attention as Selu; C-R-Z Zero-Velocity; P5, P7; U4; Study: behavioral participation, not more analysis	**Supported** that behavioral activation — scheduling engaged, valued activity — treats depression (Jacobson et al. 1996; Dimidjian et al. 2006; Ekers et al. 2014, meta-analysis). **Supported** (correlational) that feeling one matters to others relates to well-being (Elliott, Kao, and Grant 2004; Flett 2018). **Supported** that perceived burdensomeness is a suicide risk factor (Van Orden et al. 2010), hence the 988 line. **Supported**, modest effect, that kindness to others raises the giver's well-being (Curry et al. 2018; Dunn, Aknin, and Norton 2008). **Supported** that mental effort is costly and avoided (Kool et al. 2010; Shenhav et al. 2017) and that self-focused rumination impairs interpersonal problem solving (Lyubomirsky and Nolen-Hoeksema 1995). The "minimum/maximum" split as a rule: **Plausible**.

10.5 "Non-locality" and "local destiny": metaphor and faith, not physics

In quantum physics, **non-locality** has a narrow meaning. Measurements on entangled particles can show correlations that no theory of local hidden variables can reproduce (Bell 1964), and experiments have confirmed those violations (Aspect,

Dalibard, and Roger 1982). These correlations cannot be used to send signals, and they say nothing about minds, thoughts, destiny, or God. This program will therefore not use “non-local” or “like an equation” as physical claims.

Within this paper they are used as the PI’s **metaphors**: “local destiny” names the felt pull of one’s actual place and time back toward reality; “thoughts are non-local” names how thought can roam far from the room while still arising, as the PI says, from a body “bound by time and position.” The psychological content of A11 (Section 10.4) stands on its own without physics.

Values layer. “God is always with me, my Jesus Christ who is non-locality” is held by the PI as faith: Christ present everywhere and always. That is a theological conviction, not a statement about Bell inequalities, and it is recorded here in that spirit.

10.6 Techniques from the novel for ending an inner story (A3)

Finishing Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back produced several moves that can be used, as fiction-craft, on a personal loop. They are design ideas, not findings.

1. **Find the repeated line.** Neru notices she is asking her dead mother “the same question for the fourth time, in the same words” (Chapter VIII). A loop story has a refrain; naming it is the first move.
2. **Ask the Surprise Test.** Kesh: “When did she last surprise you?” (Chapter VII). If the other voice never surprises you, you are writing both parts.
3. **Let a living character say the true line.** Ilun breaks her silence: “She is dead, Neru. I am not her mouth. I am the living person in this room” (Chapter XVI). In a personal story, the true line often comes from someone else; your task is to let it land.
4. **Answer the key that needs you now.** Tulen with a cup: “Is this the color?” (Chapter VIII). “The key, this time, was his question.” The story ends when the present asks something of you.
5. **Act, out loud, with others.** At the high water Neru shouts “Heard! Knee at the stake! Heard!” (Chapter XVIII). The calling turns a private loop into shared work.
6. **Receive.** In Orun, “Receiving is an honored act,” and “a person who only ever gives and cannot receive is practicing a polite form of hoarding.” The answer “I receive it” is an ending line for a story of refusing help (A1).
7. **Let the protagonist choose.** Vethan comes home “because I wanted to,” and sets the fourth cup on the board herself (Chapter XVII). Neru’s own story ends when she stops wanting more from the dead, answers Tulen (“Heard! Coming!”), and says of the fixed morning gift, “Now it’s enough” (Chapter XX). A story ends when the person in it chooses the next real step (A2).

The Novel Analysis already warns that these scenes are kinder than real life: Ilun’s line lands without a long rupture, and the Drop works too reliably. Real endings may need many attempts and, often, professional help.

10.7 Universal Variables: Getting Out of Your Head Without Losing Yourself

The cross-check. The PI's techniques and his story were compared with C-R-Z, the Drop, P1–P7, and the novel's characters. The same structure appears in each. Something sustains the person (A5; Ilun at the west door; the dike-walkers). Something orients them to place (A7; C-R-Z Reality-Return; Neru's hand on the warm brick). Something signals the exit (the Drop's key; Tulen's question). Something ends the story (A3; Ilun's true line). Something releases shame (A6; "Do not put shame in a wound and call it medicine"). Something keeps them honest (A10; Kesh's question). Something lets them act as who they are now (A12; Neru as keeper of the rack). And something holds identity steady through all of it (A13; the values layer). Those common parts become **dials**: variables that everyone has, set differently by faith, culture, neurotype, and thinking style.

Why getting out of your head need not cost your identity. Defusion and outward attention put distance between you and a thought; they do not put distance between you and your values or your self. ACT pairs defusion with values and with a stable observing "self-as-context" (Hayes et al. 2006): you step back from "I'm worthless" precisely so that what you care about can steer. Self-distancing in self-talk (using your own name or "you") reduces distress without erasing the self who is speaking (Kross et al. 2014). Identity confidence has its own supports:

- **Self-affirmation.** Reflecting on core values protects the sense of integrity under threat and makes people less defensive and more open to change (Steele 1988; Cohen and Sherman 2014). **Supported.** This is the research neighbor of A13.
- **Self-concept clarity.** People differ in how clearly and consistently they define themselves, and clarity is associated with higher self-esteem and lower neuroticism, with cultural differences (Campbell et al. 1996). **Supported** (correlational).
- **Narrative identity.** People build identity as an evolving life story; stories that find meaning and agency in difficulty go with well-being (McAdams and McLean 2013). **Supported** (correlational). Ending a loop story (A3) is not deleting identity; it is moving to the next chapter.
- **Self-compassion, not self-esteem.** Self-esteem depends on evaluation and comparison; self-compassion — kindness, common humanity, and mindful awareness — offers steadier self-worth with less contingency and narcissism (Neff 2003; Neff and Vonk 2009). **Supported.** Identity confidence built on self-compassion does not need you to win the argument in your head.

The dials. Each row is one variable. Ryan's setting is his own. The alternates are examples, not a ranking; a person may mix them. Thinking-style options follow the UDL framing already used in this program (words, pictures, movement, logic, feelings, quiet), not fixed "learning styles" (Pashler et al. 2008).

Dial	Ryan's setting	Alternates (faiths and none, cultures, neurotypes, thinking styles)	Evidence grade	Novel link
1. Anchor person (who sustains you)	The people who kept his basic survival going during mania	A partner, friend, sibling, elder, clergy or imam or rabbi or sangha teacher, peer-support worker, therapist, group, a pet plus one human. Introverted or autistic: one predictable person, by text first. Collectivist cultures: the family or community circle	**Supported** (Cohen and Wills 1985; Holt-Lunstad et al. 2010)	Ilun at the west door; Sareth and Neru on the step
2. Anchor belief / reference point	Faith in God and Jesus Christ; "just believe"	Another faith's core teaching; secular values (honesty, care, justice); a craft or vocation; a promise to one's children; nature; a scientific attitude. Words: a sentence; pictures: an image; movement: a gesture	**Supported** that affirming core values steadies identity (Steele 1988; Cohen and Sherman 2014); content is **[Values]**	"All credit and glory to God"; Alun's firing page as a craft reference
3. Place cue (immediate position)	Awareness of his immediate position and environment	Name five things seen; feet on the floor; hand on a warm surface; a smell; a fixed object you carry; a GPS-style "I am at ___ with ___ at ___ o'clock." Logic: list; feelings: notice one comfort	**Plausible** (grounding family, U2; context effects with the Murre 2021 caution)	Neru's palm on the warm brick: "The cup was a cup"
4. Exit signal (key to reality)	A living person speaking; Christ's presence	A name called; "Where are you?" / "Here. Heard."; a timer; a doorway crossed; a phone alarm with a word; a song; a stim or fidget for ADHD or autistic users; prayer or a mantra; for quiet thinkers, a silent agreed touch	**Plausible** (U5 is the Study's question; event boundaries, Radvansky et al. 2011)	Tulen's question; the dike-walkers' calling
5. Story-ending move	End the inner story with techniques learned by finishing a fiction	Write the last paragraph; say the true line aloud; draw the final panel; act out the ending; a ritual (lighting a candle, closing a notebook); confession or examen; a therapist's re-authoring; for logic thinkers, "case closed: evidence for and against"	**Plausible** to **Speculative** (Pennebaker and Beall 1986; Frattaroli 2006; White and Epston 1990)	Ilun: "She is dead, Neru"; Neru: "Now it's enough"

Dial	Ryan's setting	Alternates (faiths and none, cultures, neurotypes, thinking styles)	Evidence grade	Novel link
6. Self-forgiveness phrase	Radical shameless acceptance; forgiven by God	"I made a mistake; I am not a mistake." "I receive it." "This is hard, and others feel it too" (self-compassion). Religious: "I am forgiven"; Buddhist: lovingkindness phrase; secular: "I own it and I'll repair it"	**Supported** (Tangney et al. 1996; MacBeth and Gumley 2012); **Plausible** for self-forgiveness with responsibility (Hall and Fincham 2005)	"Do not put shame in a wound and call it medicine"
7. Skepticism habit	Continuous skepticism; eureka comes from it	The Surprise Test; DBT "check the facts"; "What would I tell a friend?"; ask one person "does this sound right to you?"; sleep on it; a 24-hour rule for big ideas (important in mania)	**Plausible** (Sio and Ormerod 2009; Linehan 2015)	Kesh: "When did she last surprise you?"
8. "Latest self" practice	The masterpiece is the artist; regain skill by reacting to self and environment	Do one small piece of the craft today; practice with feedback; keep a "done list" not a "lost list"; return to a familiar setting; dancers: mark the steps; writers: one sentence; coders: one passing test	**Plausible** (Ericsson et al. 1993; Macnamara et al. 2014)	Neru as keeper of the rack; Tamar at the kiln
9. Energy budget	Minimum energy to think, maximum to take part in communication and reality	One small act before any analysis (behavioral activation); a "thinking window" of 10 minutes, then act; helping one person; low-energy days: one message, one walk, one true sentence; chronic illness or fatigue: pace and rest are participation too	**Supported** for components (Ekers et al. 2014; Curry et al. 2018; Lyubomirsky and Nolen-Hoeksema 1995); rule **Plausible**	Tulen: "Who's listening to the living?"; Neru: "Heard!"
10. Agency	"No one can save you except yourself" — and choosing to accept help	"I choose to call"; "I choose to take my medication"; "I walk through the door others hold." Collectivist framing: "We choose, and I take my step." Faith framing: "I cooperate with grace"	**Supported** (Ryan and Deci 2000; Bandura 1977; Leamy et al. 2011)	Orun: "People come home only by their own choice"; Vethan: "I came because I wanted to," and the fourth cup

Self-fill template. Anyone can set their own dials. Leave a line blank if it does not fit you; change it whenever you like.

My dials

1. **Anchor person.** The person (or people) who would keep me going: _____ How I reach them: _____
2. **Anchor belief / reference point.** What I stand on: _____
3. **Place cue.** How I find where I am: _____
4. **Exit signal.** The word, sound, touch, or person that means "come back": _____
5. **Story-ending move.** How I close a loop: _____
6. **Self-forgiveness phrase.** _____
7. **Skepticism habit.** How I check a thought: _____
8. **Latest-self practice.** One small thing I can do today with who I am now: _____
9. **Energy budget.** My thinking limit before I act: _____ minutes. My smallest act of taking part: _____
10. **Agency line.** "I choose to _____."
11. **My preferred route** (circle any): words · pictures · movement · logic · feelings · quiet
12. **My crisis plan is kept at:** _____ My clinician or care contact: _____ U.S. crisis line: **988**

10.8 A16 in depth: minimum to think, maximum to take part

The void of uselessness is eshva. In Orun, eshva is “the emptiness: the inward pull that narrows what a person can do,” and “Eshva is not a verdict.” The novel’s answer is never a plan demanded from inside the emptiness; it is “one small act — one loaf given, one true sentence, one walk.” That is A16 in the story’s own words, and it closely resembles behavioral activation, which schedules small, valued actions instead of waiting to feel ready (Jacobson et al. 1996; Dimidjian et al. 2006; Ekers et al. 2014).

Attention as Selu. If attention is the budget, overthinking spends it on a loop that, like hoarded selu, “grows thin.” Mental effort is genuinely costly, and people avoid it when they can (Kool et al. 2010; Shenhav et al. 2017); self-focused rumination does not even buy better solutions, since it impairs interpersonal problem solving (Lyubomirsky and Nolen-Hoeksema 1995). Spending the least needed on thinking frees the most for the room.

C-R-Z Zero-Velocity. “Minimum energy to think” is the cognitive form of Zero-Velocity: approach rest in the loop, without suppressing it, so that motion can go to participation.

The novel. Tulen asks, “If everybody’s attention goes to the rack, who’s listening to the living?” (Chapter XIX). Neru’s answer at the high water is not a thought; it is a shout: “Heard!” Mattering grows from being needed and answering (Elliott, Kao, and Grant 2004; Flett 2018), and small acts of kindness raise the giver’s well-being modestly (Curry et al. 2018).

Safety. Feeling useless is a symptom, not a measurement of worth. Perceived burdensomeness — “they would be better off without me” — is a recognized suicide risk factor (Van Orden et al. 2010). If uselessness comes with thoughts of not wanting to live, call or text **988**. And “minimum energy to think” never means switching off judgment: medication decisions, warning signs, and safety checks always get full attention.

10.9 How this fits the paired check-in study

The Accepting-Help Postulate does not change the two arms or the primary outcome. It suggests one exploratory question: **does a structured way of receiving a check-in make it easier to accept help?**

- **Proposed exploratory measure: help-seeking intentions from informal sources.** The General Help-Seeking Questionnaire (Wilson, Deane, Ciarrochi, and Rickwood 2005; instrument record verified in PsycTESTS) asks how likely a person is to seek help from named sources (partner, friend, family, professional, helpline) and is designed to be adapted to the problem and the sources of interest. It can be given at baseline and exit. Exact items, adaptation, and permissions must be confirmed in Week 1.
- **Alternatives, if a stigma measure is preferred.** The Self-Stigma of Seeking Help scale (Vogel, Wade, and Haake 2006) measures how much seeking professional help would threaten self-regard; the Attitudes Toward Seeking Professional Psychological Help–Short Form (Fischer and Farina 1995; instrument record verified) measures attitudes to professional help. Both are about professional help, so they fit less well than the GHSQ for a peer check-in, but they matter for safety referral.
- **Optional context.** The Multidimensional Scale of Perceived Social Support (Zimet et al. 1988) at baseline, to describe how supported each person feels; and, if A16 is explored, the Mattering to Others measure (Elliott, Kao, and Grant 2004).
- **Hypothesis H5 (exploratory, may fail).** Help-seeking intentions toward the partner will rise from baseline to exit in both arms, more in the arm that participants rate as easier to receive. Neither arm is presented as the “help-accepting” arm.
- **Neutral framing still applies.** Participants do not see the Accepting-Help Postulate, the sub-postulates, the dials, or any faith content. The card in 10.10 is a values-layer and personal-use tool, not study material.

10.10 The Accepting Help card

Accepting Help — a one-page card

For personal use, alongside professional care. Not a treatment. Crisis (U.S.): call or text 988. Danger: 911.

1. Let someone in (accept help first). Name one person. Send one line: "I'm in a loop. Can you ask me where I am?" When they offer, say: **"I receive it."** Receiving is not weakness; it is the first move.

2. You walk through the door. Others can hold the door and hand you a key. Only you can step through — and reaching out is stepping. Agency includes asking.

3. Spot the loop story. Same question, same words, again? Ask: **"When did this voice last surprise me?"** If never, it's my own voice.

4. End the story. Say or write the true last line, even if someone else had to say it first. Then: **"Now it's enough."**

5. Drop the rulebook. No vows, no "I must, or else." Yes is yes; no is no. Drop the shoulders; let the thought be a thought, not a command.

6. No toxic shame. "I made a mistake; I am not a mistake." Own it, repair it, move on.

7. Return to place. Feet on the floor. Name where you are, who is here, and one object. **"Where are you?" — "Here. Heard."**

8. Minimum to think, maximum to take part. Give the thought one minute, then do one small real thing: answer someone, help someone, take one walk. Feeling useless is not a fact about your worth.

9. Let the idea go. Write the passing idea down in one line and come back to the room. It will return if it is real.

10. Your latest self. Do one small piece of your craft today, as you are now.

Warning signs → crisis plan. Much less sleep, racing thoughts, big sudden plans or spending, feeling unusually certain or chosen, or thoughts of not wanting to live: stop the card, use your crisis plan, call your care team, tell your support person, and call or text **988** if you feel unsafe.

All credit and glory to God. — Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot

10.11 What this section does and does not claim

It does claim that most of the postulate’s practical moves have research neighbors, several of them strong (social support, self-compassion versus shame, understanding-based memory, defusion, behavioral activation, autonomy with relatedness). It does not claim that the postulate as a whole has been tested, that fiction-craft ends inner loops, that support people pull anyone out of mania itself, that any of this replaces medical care, or that quantum non-locality has anything to do with thought or faith. “Accept help first,” “only you can walk through,” “just believe,” and “God is always with me” are the PI’s convictions and design principles, held in the values layer.

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11. The Local Action–Thought Chain

Added in version 1.3 (13 November 2026). This section investigates a further idea from the PI, offers a working formalization, grades the evidence, and adds a practice card and an optional low-cost test. It extends A7 (position, not memory or genius), A11 (do not covet the passing idea), and A16 (minimum to think, maximum to take part). It is a conceptual extension, not a finding.

11.1 The idea, in the author's words

> investigate the genius in keeping locality of keeping an action as a thought to complete another action to end in a thought

Follow-up lines, verbatim, the same day:

> examine this ocd tendency and find ways to keep memories and not annoyed when interrupted; local reality vs non local reality preserving the choices generated from action

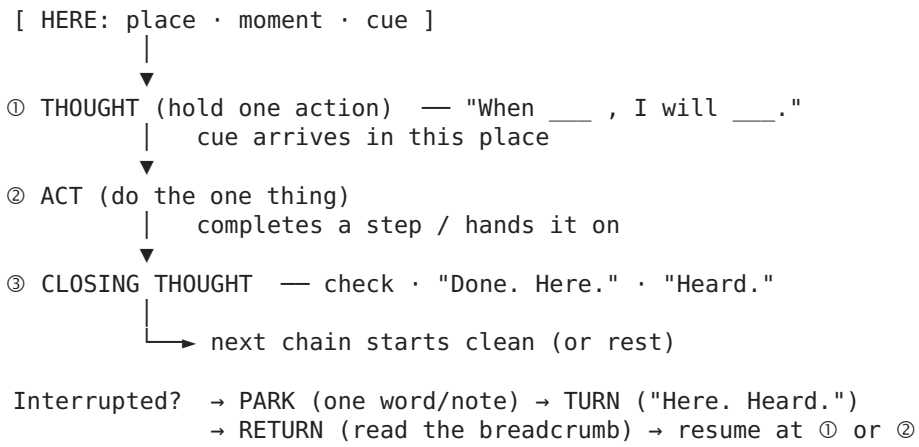
and, as a correction:

> maybe not OCD but the compelling willpower to keep reality local for the desire of purpose

11.2 The chain, in plain words

Working reading (Grok Bot's restatement, accepted as a working hypothesis, open to the PI's correction):

1. **Hold an action as a thought, here.** You hold the next intended action as a short thought, tied to where you are and what is in front of you ("When I put this cup down, I'll answer Kesh").
2. **The thought carries you to the action.** The place and the moment, not raw memory, cue the action when it comes due.
3. **The action completes another action.** Doing it finishes a step in a larger task, or hands something on to another person.
4. **Close in a thought.** The chain ends with a brief closing thought: a check, a "done," a read-back ("Heard"). Nothing is left dangling, so the next chain starts clean.



What "locality" means here. Not physics. Locality means three things kept together: **the same place** (the room, the bench, the rope line), **the same moment** (now, or the next natural pause, not "someday"), and **an environmental cue** (an object, a doorway, a person's voice, a sound) that will be present when the action is due. A chain is "local" when the thought, the cue, and the act all live in the situation you are actually in.

Where the "genius" lies, as the PI frames it. The chain does not depend on remembering everything or on brilliance. It moves the work of thinking onto **place** and **action**: the environment holds the reminder, the act does the remembering, and each small loop is closed with a thought so nothing hangs open to pull at attention later. Genius, on this reading, is a well-designed loop, not a heroic mind.

11.3 The evidence, claim by claim

Grades follow the program's tiers (**Supported**, **Plausible**, **Speculative**, **[Values]**). Every source was checked on 13 November 2026 (Section 12).

Claim	Evidence	Grade
C1. Action is organized as small test–operate–test–exit loops that close when a check is satisfied.	Miller, Galanter, and Pribram's TOTE unit (1960) is the classic model: test the state, operate, test again, exit when the test is passed. The "closing thought" is the second test and the exit.	**Supported** as an influential theoretical model; it is a framework, not a single experiment
C2. Tying an intended action to a specific cue ("When X, I will Y") makes it more likely to happen.	Implementation intentions (Gollwitzer 1999); a meta-analysis found a medium-to-large effect on goal attainment (Gollwitzer and Sheeran 2006).	**Supported**
C3. Remembering to do something later depends heavily on cues in the environment, not only on effortful memory.	Prospective memory research: intentions are often retrieved spontaneously when a distinctive cue appears, and strategic monitoring is costly (Einstein and McDaniel 1990; McDaniel and Einstein 2000, multiprocess framework).	**Supported**

Claim	Evidence	Grade
C4. People can and do offload intentions onto the environment, and this improves performance.	Cognitive offloading reviews (Risko and Gilbert 2016); people strategically set external reminders for delayed intentions (Gilbert 2015).	**Supported**. Note: offloading can reduce unaided memory for the offloaded content, which is a trade-off, not a flaw
C5. Unfinished goals keep pulling at the mind; making a concrete plan relieves the pull.	Zeigarnik (1927) on the better recall of interrupted tasks; Masicampo and Baumeister (2011) found that making a specific plan for an unfulfilled goal reduced intrusive thoughts and interference. Martin and Tesser (1996) link rumination to stalled goals.	**Supported** in the original studies; independent replication of Masicampo and Baumeister is limited, so treat the effect size with caution
C6. Thinking is partly done with the world: actions in the environment can do cognitive work.	Kirsh and Maglio (1994) showed "epistemic actions" (rotating pieces in Tetris to see the answer rather than compute it). Clark and Chalmers (1998) argued that external props can be part of the cognitive process (the "extended mind").	**Supported** for epistemic actions (empirical); **Plausible / philosophical** for the strong extended-mind claim
C7. Changing location can drop a held intention, so keeping the chain local protects it.	Walking through a doorway impaired memory for objects just handled (Radvansky and Copeland 2006; Radvansky, Krawietz, and Tamplin 2011), consistent with event segmentation theory (Zacks et al. 2007). But a 2021 multi-experiment study found doorways do not always cause forgetting (McFadyen et al. 2021).	**Plausible.** The doorway effect is real in some conditions and fragile in others. The practical tip (say the intention as you cross, or finish the chain before you leave) is low-cost either way
C8. Switching away from a task leaves a residual cost, so closing a loop before switching helps.	Task-switching costs persist even with preparation (Monsell 2003). Leaving a task unfinished leaves "attention residue" that lowers performance on the next task (Leroy 2009).	**Supported**
C9. Repeated chains in a stable context become habits that need little thought.	Habits are context-cued response dispositions that run with little deliberation once formed (Wood and Neal 2007).	**Supported**; it also means a chain practiced in a bad context becomes a bad habit
C10. In skilled, absorbed action, awareness and action merge.	Csikszentmihalyi (1990) described flow as including the merging of action and awareness, clear goals, and immediate feedback. A short flow scale exists (Engeser and Rheinberg 2008).	**Supported** as a well-described experience; causal claims about chaining producing flow are **Plausible**
C11. Experts chain steps fluidly because practiced knowledge in long-term memory acts like an extended working memory.	Long-term working memory (Ericsson and Kintsch 1995).	**Supported** for experts in their domain; for everyday chaining it is a **Plausible** analogy

Claim	Evidence	Grade
C12. The chain is the "genius": offloading onto place and closing small loops matters more than memory or brilliance.	Follows from C2–C9 together, and fits A7 and A16. No study tests the full chain as a package.	**Plausible** as a design principle; the word "genius" is **[Values]**
C13. Rumination is an open loop; mania is a racing chain that does not close.	Rumination as repetitive, goal-stalled thought (Martin and Tesser 1996; Nolen-Hoeksema, Wisco, and Lyubomirsky 2008). Racing thoughts and flight of ideas are DSM-5-TR features of mania (American Psychiatric Association 2022). The "closing" framing of both is ours.	**Supported** for the descriptions; the chain framing is **Plausible** as a metaphor and **must not** be used as a treatment for mania

11.4 Where the "genius" is, and where it fails

Three design features carry the weight.

- **Offload onto place.** Let a cue in the room do the remembering (C3, C4). This is A7 made practical.
- **Keep loops small.** One thought, one act. Small loops close often, so few are left open to pull at you (C5, C8).
- **Close every loop with a thought.** "Done. Here." The closing thought is the TOTE exit (C1). It tells the mind the goal is met, or parked with a plan, so it can let go (C5).

Contrast 1: rumination. Rumination is a loop that never reaches its exit test. The same question repeats; no act follows; nothing closes. The chain's answer is to convert the loop into one act and one closing thought, or to park it with a written plan (C5). This is the Connection Postulate's P1 seen from the action side: unfinished purposes stay active until completed or released.

Contrast 2: mania. In mania, chains race: thought jumps to thought, plan to plan, and few acts complete. More chaining is not the answer. The safe rule is fewer, slower, closed loops — and, above all, the warning-sign plan in Section 10.1. If thoughts are racing and sleep is dropping, the chain card is set aside and the crisis plan is used.

11.5 When the chain must close: purpose-driven willpower to keep reality local, kept harmonious

Lead. The PI corrected the framing himself: this is "maybe not OCD but the compelling willpower to keep reality local for the desire of purpose." That is a **strength**: a purpose-driven drive to stay in the real, present situation and finish what one has started. The research question is not "is this a symptom?" but **"how is the drive kept harmonious, so it can make room for interruptions, memory gaps, and other people?"**

What the drive draws on.

- **Purpose.** A stable sense of purpose organizes goals and behavior and is associated with health and well-being (McKnight and Kashdan 2009); purpose in life is one of Ryff's six dimensions of psychological well-being (Ryff 1989). **Supported** (largely correlational).
- **Perseverance.** Grit, defined as perseverance and passion for long-term goals, predicted achievement in several samples (Duckworth et al. 2007). A later meta-analysis found grit's effects modest and largely overlapping with conscientiousness, with perseverance the more useful facet (Credé, Tynan, and Harms 2017). **Supported, with that critique**: perseverance matters; "grit" is not a magic separate trait.
- **Self-control as alignment, not raw force.** Self-control is better understood as acting in line with one's higher-order goals, often by arranging situations and construals, than as effortful muscle (Fujita 2011). The "limited willpower" story has been challenged; motivation and attention shifts explain much of apparent depletion (Inzlicht, Schmeichel, and Macrae 2014; Inzlicht et al. 2021). **Supported.** This is why the chain uses cues and places rather than force: willpower works best when the environment carries it.

The key distinction: harmonious versus obsessive passion. Vallerand and colleagues (2003) distinguished **harmonious passion** — an activity freely chosen, integrated with the rest of life, flexible, and able to be set down — from **obsessive passion** — a rigid, internally pressured engagement that conflicts with other parts of life and brings frustration and rumination when blocked. A meta-analysis of a decade of research found harmonious passion associated with positive outcomes and obsessive passion with more negative affect and conflict (Curran et al. 2015). **Supported.** Keeping reality local "for the desire of purpose" is harmonious when the drive is chosen and flexible, and makes room for interruption. It turns obsessive when being blocked feels intolerable.

Boundary note: when to ask a professional. A strong wish to finish things is common and healthy. It is worth an evaluation by a clinician if loops start to feel compelled rather than chosen; if you feel you must repeat, check, or arrange until it feels "just right" (Coles et al. 2003; Summerfeldt 2004); if unwanted intrusive thoughts cause marked distress; or if rituals take more than about an hour a day or interfere with work, relationships, or sleep (American Psychiatric Association 2022). This paper does not diagnose. If OCD is diagnosed, cognitive-behavioral therapy with exposure and response prevention (ERP) is the first-line psychological treatment (Abramowitz, Taylor, and McKay 2009; NICE 2005; Olatunji et al. 2013). A general need for closure is a separate, normal personality dimension (Webster and Kruglanski 1994).

11.5.1 Keeping memories through interruptions

- **Interruptions cost something real.** Resuming a suspended goal takes time, and the cost grows with the length and demand of the interruption (Altmann and Trafton 2002, memory for goals; Monk, Trafton, and Boehm-Davis 2008). **Supported.**
- **A breadcrumb before switching helps.** Leaving a task unfinished produces attention residue (Leroy 2009). A brief "ready-to-resume plan" — noting where you are and what comes next before you turn to the interruption — reduced residue and improved performance on the interrupting task (Leroy and Glomb 2018). **Supported** (laboratory and field-like studies).
- **Write the plan down.** A specific written plan lowers the intrusive pull of an unfinished goal (Masicampo and Baumeister 2011). **Supported**, with the replication caution in C5.
- **Let the environment hold it.** A sticky note, a phone note, or an object placed where you will see it is legitimate memory (Risko and Gilbert 2016). **Supported.**

11.5.2 Not getting annoyed: the interruption is the living key

In this research program, the interruption is often the very thing the framework asks for: a **living key**. Tulen's "Is this the color?" broke Neru's loop (Chapter VIII). The skill is to treat a flash of frustration as a **cue**, not a threat: "my chain was running; a person needs me; park and turn."

- **Reappraisal.** Changing how a situation is interpreted is an effective emotion-regulation strategy, generally better than suppressing the feeling (Gross 1998; Gross and John 2003; meta-analysis, Webb, Miles, and Sheeran 2012). "An interruption is a person, not an obstacle" is a reappraisal. **Supported.**
- **Willingness.** ACT treats experiential avoidance, the struggle to not feel what one feels, as a driver of distress, and willingness as the alternative (Hayes et al. 1996; Hayes et al. 2006). You can feel the tug of the unfinished chain and still turn. **Supported** as a model; **Plausible** in this application.

The 5-second "park it" ritual.

1. **Park** (2 seconds). One word or a note marking where you were: "rope," "line 3," "email to Kesh, second paragraph."
2. **Turn** (1 second). Face the person. "Here. Heard."
3. **Return** (later). Read the breadcrumb and resume at the thought or the act.

11.5.3 Local and non-local reality: the local wins now, the non-local is parked, not held

Using the PI's terms as **metaphor**: **local reality** is the present place, the body, and the person in front of you; **non-local reality** is the thought-space, where ideas, plans, and imagined conversations roam. (This is not physics; see Section 10.5. Faith claims about Christ's non-locality stay in the values layer.)

The rule. In the moment, the local wins. The non-local is preserved by a parked note, not held by force. Holding an idea by force while someone is speaking is the cost the research describes as residue and switch cost (C8). Parking it costs seconds and keeps it.

The novel shows this exactly. At the high water Neru is holding her mother's map, and a voice says Look again. "She let go. Not of her mother. Of the map." The original is safe on the rack; she does not need to hold the copy. Then she answers the living call: "Heard! Knee at the stake!" (Chapter XVIII). The non-local is safe elsewhere; the local gets her whole voice.

11.5.4 Preserving the choices generated from action: the choice ledger

Every action opens new options: someone to thank, a follow-up, an idea for the next work. Chasing each one at once breaks the chain. Ignoring them all loses them.

The choice ledger. Keep one running list. When an action opens a choice, write it in one line ("Ask Kesh about the old posts"). Review the ledger once a day, pick what to act on, and let the rest go.

This is A11 in practice: do not covet the passing idea; write it down and come back to the room. It is also selu: **choices that sit unused also fade, and that is all right.** A ledger is a keeping, not a hoard. Nothing in the ledger is owed.

Evidence: written plans and external notes relieve the pull of unfinished goals (Masicampo and Baumeister 2011; Risko and Gilbert 2016): **Supported** for the mechanism. A daily-review choice ledger as a practice: **Plausible**, untested.

11.6 The chain in the novel and in the dials

The calling at the high water is a local action–thought chain. Vethan calls a position ("Knee at the stake!"). Neru reads it back ("Heard! Knee at the stake!") — a thought held aloud. Vethan takes one step to the next post — the act. The next call and read-back close that step and open the next. The sequence ends with Kesh's "Line's across!" and Neru's "Heard! Line's across!" — the closing thought for the whole chain (Chapter XVIII). Each loop is local (one post, one step, one voice), small, and closed with a word. That is why it works under pressure: no one has to remember the river; they only have to say what is here and answer.

Other scenes. Tulen's question (Chapter VIII) is an interruption that becomes a key. Neru letting go of the map is a park. Ilun's "I listen" is the turn.

Mapping to the Universal Variables (Section 10.7).

Dial	Role in the chain
3. Place cue	Where the thought is anchored (step ①)
4. Exit signal	The closing thought or read-back (step ③); also the interruption that becomes a key
5. Story-ending move	Closing a loop with a thought rather than leaving it open
7. Skepticism habit	The TOTE test: is it actually done?
8. "Latest self" practice	One small chain of the craft today
9. Energy budget	One thought, then act; minimum to think, maximum to take part
10. Agency	You choose to park, turn, and return

11.7 Practice card: one thought → one act → one closing thought

One thought → one act → one closing thought

A practice for everyday tasks, alongside any care you receive. Not a treatment. Crisis (U.S.): call or text 988.

1. One thought, here. Tie the next action to something in front of you. "When I set this cup down, I'll text Kesh."

2. One act. When the cue arrives, do the one thing. Not three.

3. One closing thought. Check it, then close it: **"Done. Here."** (With another person: **"Heard."**)

Doorway tip. Leaving the room? Say the intention as you cross ("keys, keys"), or finish the chain before you go.

Interrupted? Park it, Turn, Return.

Park it — one word or a note where you are ("line 3").
Turn — face the person: "Here. Heard." The interruption may be your living key.
Return — read your breadcrumb and pick up at the thought or the act.

Choice ledger. When an action opens a new option, write it in one line. Review once a day. Let the rest fade; nothing in it is owed.

Keep the drive harmonious. Chosen, flexible, and able to pause. If it starts to feel compelled, or being blocked feels unbearable, slow down and talk to someone.

Not for racing thoughts. If thoughts are racing and sleep is dropping, set this card aside and use your crisis plan. Call or text **988** if you feel unsafe.

All credit and glory to God. — Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot

11.8 An optional, cheap test

Option A: a solo micro-study (preferred first). A within-person, two-week ABAB-style self-experiment, or a small randomized micro-study under ethics review if it involves anyone beyond the PI.

- **Design.** Alternate days (or week halves) between the chain card (one thought → one act → closing thought, with park-it for interruptions) and ordinary practice.
- **Measures.**
  - Everyday prospective-memory lapses: Prospective and Retrospective Memory Questionnaire (Smith, Della Sala, Logie, and Maylor 2000), pre and post, with a daily count of “intended but forgot” items as a feasibility outcome.
  - Workload: NASA Task Load Index (Hart and Staveland 1988), end of day.
  - Flow: Flow Short Scale (Rheinberg, Vollmeyer, and Engeser 2003, instrument record; see Engeser and Rheinberg 2008), end of day.
  - Brooding: RRS brooding items, already in the study measure set (Treynor et al. 2003), pre and post.
  - Daily “open loops” count and an interruption-annoyance rating (0–10): **new single items, unvalidated**, labeled as such.

    - Optional: the Passion Scale (Vallerand et al. 2003, instrument record) at baseline, to see whether harmonious or obsessive passion moderates the effect.

- **Prediction (may fail).** Chain days show fewer prospective-memory lapses, fewer open loops at day's end, and lower annoyance at interruptions, without higher workload.

Option B: a rider on the paired study. Add two daily items to the Section 6 EMA — "How many loops did you leave open today?" and "When interrupted today, how annoyed were you (0–10)?" — as exploratory, unvalidated items. No change to arms or primary outcome. This is optional and should be weighed against participant burden.

Safety in both. Exclude current mania or psychosis, as Section 6 already does; give the 988 notice; stop if distress rises.

11.9 What this section does and does not claim

It does claim that the main parts of the chain — cue-tied intentions, environmental offloading, closing loops with a plan, and breadcrumbs before switching — each have solid support. It does not claim the full chain has been tested, that it treats rumination, OCD, or mania, or that "local" and "non-local" are physics. "Genius" here is the PI's word for a well-designed loop; it is held as a value, not a finding.

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12. References

Works are split so that nothing unverified can be mistaken for a source. Entries 110–152 were added in version 1.3 and checked the same way. Entries 48–109 were added in version 1.2 and were checked the same day against Crossref, PsycTESTS, Open Library, or a record already verified in the C-R-Z paper or v1.0. Unless a note says otherwise, verified entries were confirmed on 13 November 2026 against Crossref, a publisher page, PubMed or PMC, or a record already verified in version 1.0 of the unified paper. Instrument-source papers that Gemini did not itself cite, but that we looked up because Gemini named the instrument, are marked **[instrument lookup]**.

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12.2 Pending or unverified

1. **Ikkatai, Y., et al. (2023).** Gemini cited this as an experimental study of depreciating currency and circulation velocity. No matching paper was found on 13 November 2026. Do not cite.
2. **Champ, B., Freeman, S., and W. E. Weber (2003).** Gemini cited this as a reading on depreciating currency. No 2003 paper by these authors on demurrage was found. Do not cite under this name or year. (A 1999 paper by the same three authors, and a 2008 sole-authored commentary by Champ on stamp scrip, exist but are different works and are not used as repaired substitutes here.)
3. **Quantitative figures for the Wörgl (1932–1933) stamp-scrip episode** (turnover, unemployment, or circulation multiples). The episode is historically attested in secondary sources, but the figures have not been checked against a primary source for this program and must not be used as data.
4. **Rosenberg, M., and B. C. McCullough (1981), “Mattering: inferred significance and mental health among adolescents,”** usually cited in Research in Community and Mental Health 2. It is the classic origin of the mattering concept, but no Crossref record was found and the volume could not be checked for this version. It is not cited in Section 10; mattering is cited through Elliott, Kao, and Grant (2004) and Flett (2018) instead.
5. **Scripture** (Matthew 5:34–37; John 16:33, King James Version) is quoted in the values layer as conviction, not as evidence.

Related works in this collection

- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Orun Unified Research: Returning to the Living, version 1.0 (13 November 2026), with the Technical Companion and Analysis of the Novel. https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/orun-unified/Orun-Unified-Research.pdf
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, The C-R-Z Framework: Calibration, Reality-Return, and Zero-Velocity (13 November 2026). https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/c-r-z-framework/C-R-Z-Framework.pdf

- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Selu Cannot Buy the Morning Back: A novel of Orun (2026; some scenes first drafted with Microsoft Copilot).
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Checkpoint v1.2 (13 November 2026), kept unchanged in the same folder.
- Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot, Checkpoint v1.1 (13 November 2026), kept unchanged: https://ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/checkpoint-v1.1/Checkpoint-Gemini-Collaboration-v1.1.pdf
- Google Gemini review session, “Everyday help” model, 13 November 2026, https://gemini.google.com/app/90c713738868da46, transcripts in this folder.

AI assistance

Grok Bot helped draft this checkpoint, including the v1.2 restatement, cross-checks, and citation audit of the Accepting-Help Postulate and the v1.3 investigation of the action–thought chain, under the author’s direction, sent the prompts, and checked the literature. Google Gemini provided the external review, the three directions, and the first 30-day plan. Microsoft Copilot contributed draft scenes to the novel only. None of these assistants is a co-investigator or a source of primary evidence.

Values layer

The author holds, as a matter of faith, that all credit and glory belong to God. He holds that a higher power has overcome the world: “In the world ye shall have tribulation: but be of good cheer; I have overcome the world” (John 16:33, King James Version). He holds that respect for God and for the people who reach out to us means connection takes priority, within the limits of safety, consent, and one’s own needs, and he hopes that when memories fade, love remains. He holds that one should not bind oneself by oaths but simply believe: “Swear not at all; neither by heaven… nor by the earth… But let your communication be, Yea, yea; Nay, nay” (Matthew 5:34–37, King James Version). He holds that God is always with him, and that Jesus Christ is “non-local” in the sense of being present everywhere and always — a theological conviction, not a physical claim. He holds that others can hold the door, and that each person must choose to walk through it. These convictions say what the work is for. They are not findings, and they are not hypotheses of the draft protocol.

All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

Ryan Espinosa, with Grok Bot; external review by Google Gemini. If you are in crisis in the United States, call or text 988.